

Combating Gender Based Violence in Leadership: Interrogating Patriarchal Cultural Structure in Tess Osonye Onwueme's *The Reign of Wazobia*

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Abstract

*One in three women globally will or has being subjected to gender based violence in her lifetime. Significantly, women remain under represented at all spheres of leadership roles and decision making responsibility. This phenomenon within Nigerian societies represents a significant impediment to equitable leadership, excellence leadership structure, and the overall well-being of the Nigerian social, cultural and formal structured communities. This study interrogates the manifestations in Leadership, highlighting the statistics of gender-based violence on women in leadership, discussing the intersectionality and consequences of gender based violence GBV in leadership in Nigerian. This study argues for a pluralistic approach to actively combat GBV, drawing on the socio-cultural context in Nigeria and the unique power dynamics within cultural, academic, political, economic institutions, this paper highlights the urgent need for comprehensive strategies encompassing robust policy frameworks, effective reporting mechanisms, and proactive prevention initiatives. This research underscores the importance of empowering women through mentorship, leadership training, and the creation of safe spaces for dialogue and support, fostering an environment free from Gender Based Violence is crucial for cultivating inclusive and effective leadership that can drive positive transformation in Nigeria and beyond. This research is qualitative in nature, as it embraces a textual analysis of *The Reign of Wazobia* by Tess Osonye Onwueme and content analysis of related literature. Anchored on Intersectional Theory and Feminist Theory of Change (FToC) to review the nature and basis of violence against women, gender stratification and projecting how it is patriarchal induced and structurally imposed and also suggest for gender equity and a violence free society. The findings of study concludes that gender based violence in leadership in Nigerian is as a result of patriarchal structure, laced with socio-cultural and environmental factors.*

Keywords: Gender Based Violence, Leadership, Patriarchy, African Culture, Empowerment.

Introduction

Gender-based violence (GBV) in leadership is a harmful acts directed at individuals in leadership positions or those aspiring to leadership, specifically because of their gender. It is rooted in gender inequality and power imbalances and aims to undermine their authority, participation, and well-being. Strid Sofia projects that gender based violence is a pervasive, persistent and prevalent global problem connected to crime, capital, power and other hegemony and a human rights violation (4). It clearly, connotes that gender based violence is far beyond common act but also holds a serious human rights violations which affects the victims wellbeing and existence as the act is gravely accompanied by crime perpetuations, which in turn leaves a lifelong scars. Eze Prince and Okonkwo Nnamdi propose that gender-based violence (GBV) is a global issue that transcends borders, cultures, and socio-economic classes (319). Relatively, gender based violence in leadership in Nigerian is a significant issue that intersect with power

dynamics, cultural norms and institutional policies, gender-based violence in leadership is a critical issue that significantly impacts women's access to and participation in leadership roles across various sectors, including politics, business, and community organizations.

United Nation Women Africa (UN Women) 2026 views gender-based violence in leadership as a critical barrier to equality, functioning as a structural tool to hinder women's political, economic and public participation. It often takes the form of online harassment, sexual abuse and discrimination designed to discredit female leaders and deter them from decision-making roles. Generally, gender-based violence (GBV) acts as a formidable barrier, preventing women from fully contributing their skills and perspectives. Odebode Olasunbo Stella suggests that the intersection of gender discrimination and violence severely hampers women's educational aspirations, limiting their ability to excel and pursue certain career opportunities (14). The school environment is an intended space for learning and growth thus becomes a site of vulnerability for female students, affecting their academic career and achievement as well as stating a defect to their future profession becomes a reason for attention.

This phenomenon is a reproving global human rights issue, which is prevalent in Africa, basically in the Nigerian Universities specifically in the domain of women in leadership. There is no gainsaying in emphasizing the importance of women empowerment, as it equip women the necessary ability and voice to decision making and self representation and participation in the matters of their society. Chikada Daniel, Philip Jim Umaru and Ni'ima Oluwaseun Nchi confirm that, women empowerment includes the action of raising the status of women through education, raising awareness, literacy, and training (128). Women's empowerment is all about equipping and allowing women make life-determining decisions through the different problems in society as well as participating in leadership roles and discharging socio-cultural responsibilities. Therefore, there is need to advocate for a society free of women underrepresentation and gender based violence in leadership. Gender based violence in leadership is socio-culturally and institutionally induced which is as a result of patriarchal nature of the Nigerian societies, gender-based violence cuts across every level of leadership spheres in the Nigerian tertiary institutions, right from student union leadership positions, non-academic down to the academic domain. Significantly the inclusion and participation of women is considerably low compare to the men folks which is as a result of gender inequality and equity among the sexes. However, women experience in the course of assuming and carrying out their duties and responsibilities as leaders is tough and challenging.

Corroborating with this, Uduaghan-Akpoti Natasha a Chairman, Senate Committee on Diaspora and NGOs in an article on Business Day online news, 2025, titled Backlash Against Gender Inclusivity Setback for Development, comments that the need to break systemic barriers that hinder women's participation in leadership and to strengthen policies that protect women from political violence and discrimination (2). Drawing from the above conclusion, it is without any doubt, that women in every level and public spheres face one form of gender violence or another, in terms of leadership and power assumption in the Nigerian society, which appears to be a systemic act, and it is deliberate and cultural for the purpose of indirectly forcing the exclusion of women out of the leadership positions. In this note, Eze and Nnamdi further posit that indeed, the intersectionality of ethnicity, gender-based violence, class and religion has increased the level of underrepresentation of women in political and leadership roles in Nigeria (323). Calling attention to the fact that there is urgent need for implementation of policies and

stating reasons for women participation as linked to not only to the development of women but also to the global betterment. She furthers her argument as thus:

The backlash against gender inclusivity in politics and security is not just a setback for women; it is a setback for global development. The world must move beyond rhetoric and take concrete actions to ensure that women are not just included in peace and security discussions but are given equal opportunities to lead and influence policies (2).

Therefore, the need for combating gender based violence in leadership in Nigerian calls for urgent deliberation and institutional implementation of training problems for women in formal work spheres, traditional leadership positions and junior schools and university staff and students for conscientisation and gender sensitivity. Ezeaka Benedeth Nonye & Bartholomew Evelyn Chinenye assert that:

A critical challenges in addressing GBV in Nigeria is the inadequate and effective use of communication in prevention and intervention efforts while various public awareness campaigns have been launched to address GBV, many have failed to create significant impact due to poor message framing, limited audience reach and inadequate grass root engagement (4).

Perhaps, this indicates that the persistence of gender-based violence is as a result of insufficient preventive communication and rigorous intervention from social circle, cultural institutions, Nigerian universities communities as well as governmental agencies in launching strategic awareness campaigns in addressing gender based violence, which many attempts have proven abortive.

Theoretical Background

The theoretical background of this study is fashioned on Intersectional Theory and Feminist Theory of Change (FToC). Intersectionality Theory, first coined by Kimberlé Crenshaw in 1989, is a framework used to understand how various forms of inequality, discrimination, and social identities (such as race, gender, class, sexuality, and disability) intersect and overlap. It emphasizes that people are not defined by a single social category but by multiple interconnected aspects of their identity that can result in unique experiences of privilege or oppression.

Intersectionality Theory suggests that individuals' lives and experiences are shaped by a matrix of social categories that interact in ways that cannot be separated. For instance, a Black woman might face different challenges from a white woman or a Black man due to the intersections of race and gender. This concept goes beyond examining individuals through the lens of single-axis thinking (such as just focusing on gender or race alone). Instead, it urges an understanding of how these identities combine to create specific experiences of marginalisation or advantage.

A Feminist Theory of Change (FToC) is a strategic framework that maps how interventions can disrupt unequal power structures such as patriarchy and capitalism to achieve gender equality. Rather than treating change as linear, it focuses on long-term systemic shifts, intersectional equity, and the empowerment of marginalized voices across all levels of society. However, Feminist Theory of Change (FToC) is not attributed to a single founder. Instead, it emerged as a collaborative framework developed collectively by global feminist movements, researchers,

and organizations (like the Association for Women's Rights in Development (AWID) and Just Associates) to challenge traditional, top-down development models. Cmiconsortium.orgFToC emphasizes that social change is complex, non-linear, and fundamentally rooted in shifting power dynamics. Key contributors who shaped its methodology include, Ranjani K. Murthy a prominent evaluator and gender researcher who outlined foundational frameworks for feminist evaluation and structural transformation, “ResearchGateGender@Work” a collaborative network of researchers and activists who co-created frameworks linking gender equality, individual agency, and institutional power structures and “We Are Purposeful” by Kimberlé Crenshaw who coined intersectionality, which remains a core pillar of modern FToC, highlighting how compounding identities (race, class, gender) affect experiences of inequality.

The core principles of FToC include Intersectionality which recognizes that gender is never isolated, it intersects with race, class, sexuality, ability, and geographic location to shape experiences of discrimination another is power as a central dynamic, this argues that FToC analyzes power to “agency and capacity to act”, power with “collective power”, and power within “self-worth”, actively seeking to dismantle the "power over" others, this navigates towards dismantling patriarchal superiority over women in the society. Thirdly is process over product highlighting that how change happens is just as important as the outcome. Feminist Theory of Change FToC values inclusive decision-making, care for activists to prevent burnout, and political integrity in both internal and external operations. The other is mobilizing power by creating and strengthening movements, fostering cross-sectoral collaborations, and amplifying feminist voices and transforming power changing policies, laws, and institutional norms that maintain inequalities, as well as shifting cultural narratives to validate women's rights and bodily autonomy and the application and impact of this theory is utilized across various sectors, including international development, philanthropy, human rights, and the workplace, to set realistic expectations. It forces institutions to challenge extractive systems, prioritize care and regeneration over endless growth, and ensure that those most affected by systemic injustice are leading the solutions.

Intersectionality Theory and Feminist Theory of Change are vital concepts in understanding how complex systems of oppression work. They challenge organisations to think beyond single-axis categories and to consider the many identities individuals hold. By acknowledging the interconnected nature of social categories, organisations can foster more inclusive, equitable, and supportive environments that truly embrace diversity and eradicating patriarchal power structure, race, religious influence and socio-cultural induced gender-based violence in leadership in our society at large.

Intersectionality: The Role of Culture, Religion and Social Construction on Gender-Based Violence

The intersectionality of culture, religion and social construction generates a complex web that often perpetuates gender-based violence by normalizing male dominance and female subordination. These mentioned factors do not act in isolation, but rather create specific generally oppressive, environments where violence against women is justified, concealed or ignored. Culture, religion, and social constructs intersect to create deeply ingrained systems of power that normalize and perpetuate gender-based violence (GBV). These overlapping factors act as interlocking frameworks that define acceptable behavior, dictate power dynamics, and

often shield perpetrators from accountability. Ayegbemi Moshood posits that social construction of gender roles, society constructs rigid definitions of masculinity and femininity (38). Often, masculinity is associated with dominance, stoicism, and control, while femininity is equated with submissiveness and passivity. Worthy to note on intersectionality on gender based violence in leadership is power hierarchy, this arbitrary construction establish men as the primary authority figures and decision-makers. Eziwho Emenike Azunwo attests that:

Due to the patriarchal system that pervades the society, women are not often guaranteed a place in their family of origin. Even though most societies proscribe violence against women, the reality is that violation against women's right are often sanction under the garb of cultural practices and norms, although misinterpretation of religious tenets abound (12).

Consequently, when these established patriarchal structures and roles are challenged, or when men feel their dominance is threatened, it frequently manifests as violence to reassert control. Significantly to note is normalization, our social conditioning often teaches victims to tolerate, minimize, or internalize abuse, perpetuating a continuous cycle of violence.

Cultural Norms and Traditions Patriarchy and Honor, many cultures are rooted in patriarchal structures that prioritize family "honor" over individual well-being. This can lead to the justification of violence (such as so-called "honor killings" or female genital mutilation) to preserve family reputation. David Maurine confirms that tolerance and complicity Cultural practices like bride price, dowries, or forced marriages can commodify women, treating them as property rather than autonomous individuals (15). Since inception, patriarchy has played out on women existence, cultural silence around "private family matters" often prevents victims from seeking help. Institutional Authority Religious institutions are frequently led by men, which can reinforce unequal power dynamics. In some communities, religious leaders may counsel victims to remain in abusive marriages for the sake of sanctity or family preservation, inadvertently enabling the violence. Ade Joy maintains that misinterpreted concepts of purity, modesty, and duty can place the burden of moral rectitude entirely on women, creating an environment where victim-blaming thrives if an assault occurs (142). In the same note, Idowu Ajibola, Kikelomo Israel Oluseyi et al assert that studies have shown that patriarchal family system, male dominance and gender stereotype are major reasons for GBV perpetration in many cultures (6). The Intersectional effect of these elements means that their impacts are multiplicative rather than additive. A woman living in a highly patriarchal culture, guided by strict religious tenets, and facing systemic social marginalization (like poverty or lack of education) experiences a drastically amplified risk of GBV, compounded by severe barriers to getting help.

Statistics of Gender-Based Violence on Women in Leadership

Situating from the above discussions on gender based violence in leadership, it is of interest to note that as ugly as the act may be, it has become a recurrent experience and widely spread across nations. Adeyanju Abash in a study conducted on gender violence in leadership in Nigerian, reports that, globally, nearly 1 in 3 women have experienced physical or sexual violence by an intimate partner or non-partner at least once in their lifetime. Women remain significantly underrepresented at all levels of political decision-making worldwide. As of January 2025, only 28 women serve as Heads of State and/or Government across 25 countries.

81.8% of women parliamentarians have reported experiencing some form of violence, including death threats, threats of rape, or abduction. In 2024, only 27% of national parliamentarians worldwide were women, and this figure drops to 21% in conflict-affected countries.

Manifestations of Gender-Based Violence in Leadership

Gender-based Violence against women in leadership tend to impede access to leadership, this acts includes physical violence, intimidation, threats, and harassment that deter women from seeking or taking up leadership positions. COLTA suggest that Gender based violence in cultural leadership institutions often manifests through hierarchal structures that silence victims and uphold harmful practices, including child marriage and sexual abuse, often under the guise of tradition (13). For instance, women in politics may face threats of rape, death threats, or abduction.

- i. Women in leadership positions may experience cultural manipulations, sexual harassment, bullying, cyber bullying, and psychological abuse targeted at undermining and demining their authority and forcing them out of their leadership roles.
- ii. Physical Violence in this sense involves physical threats, intimidation, or physical harm directed at women and girls occupying leadership positions .
- iii. Cloud violence, recently, digital spaces have become a platform for gender-based violence against women in leadership, including online intimidation, cyber bullying, online harassment, spreading malicious content, or threats through digital platforms, hate speech, and the spread of harmful content.
- iv. Structurally, this involves the deliberate exclusion of women from leadership roles through discriminatory laws, policies, and practices, as well as harmful social norms and stereotypes that portray women as less capable leaders. The unequal burden of unpaid care work also limits women's time and opportunities for leadership.
- v. Psychological/Emotional violence, this has to do with verbal abuse, bullying, intimidation, spreading rumors, undermining their credibility, or exclusion from decision-making processes.
- vi. Economic violence involves sabotaging their work, denying resources or opportunities, or economic exploitation.
- vii. Sexual violence culminates a situation whereby women and girls experience sexual harassment, assault, unconsented gestures or threats of sexual violence.

Consequences of Gender Based Violence GBV in leadership in Nigerian

The consequences of GBV on women in leadership are far-reaching, this involves or obstructs access to leadership. Violence against women prevents them from entering and progressing in leadership roles, leading to their underrepresentation in decision-making and equal participation. Ussain Mohammed, concludes that the psychological impact of gender-based

violence in the universities is profound and long lasting (6). The impact of gender-based violence is not only associated women or girls, to students as victims but as well as the female staff of the university, women in social or traditional leadership positions but also generate fear of participation, discrimination, stereotype, exclusion and abuse of power assumed.

Gender-based violence in Leadership in Nigerian can lead to several detrimental consequences, which include a decline in student performance, a decrease in female enrollment and a perception of campus environments. This could obstruct women's access to leadership, which in turns creates a hostile environment that discourages women from seeking or remaining in leadership roles. Prince Eze and Okonkwo Nnamdi posit that gender based violence reduces the number of women willing to contest elections or pursue leadership positions within political parties and government institutions thereby leading to a wider gap of gender inequality in the political space (323). The effect of GBV limits the participation and influence the large gap in women willingness to aspire or take leadership role in the Nigerian society, even when women are in leadership, this said phenomenon can hinder their ability to participate effectively and influence their decisions. The effect of this nomenclature most times pose harm to well-being, triggering psychological distress, fear, anxiety, and can negatively impact the physical and mental health of the targeted individuals (women/girls). Whereby, undermining democracy and governance, by silencing or removing individuals based on their gender, it weakens democratic processes and inclusive governance. It reinforces harmful gender stereotypes and power imbalances, making it harder to achieve gender equality.

Approaches in Addressing Gender-Based Violence in Leadership

UN Women Africa (2026) support that no cultural practice, tradition or social norm should be used to justify or enable any form of violence against women and girls. Such acts are a clear violation of human rights and dignity and they undermine the very values that traditional institutions are meant to uphold (2). Considering the significance of the eradication of gender-based violence against women in leadership, it is imperative

Challenge Patriarchal Structures

Strategizing steps to recognize and actively work to dismantle the patriarchal structures and gender inequalities that contribute to GBV in leadership and the broader social environment should be taken. The under-representation of women in senior positions can worsen the issue.

Promote Gender Equality in Leadership

Purposeful implementation of strategies to increase the representation of women in leadership positions within social, economic, cultural and political environments should be put in place. Hence, gender sensitivity in appointments should be prioritized. Hence, creating and maintaining responsible and reliable system structure which takes absolute recognition for gender equality and equity at every level involved will promote gender equality and equity.

Address Harmful Gender Norms

Actively challenge and work to change the harmful gender norms, traditional beliefs, and practices that perpetuate GBV. The purposeful impulsion of communication strategies such as

interpersonal communication, social marketing, and behavioral change campaigns have been effective in promoting positive attitudes against gender discrimination, subjugation and violence.

Ensuring Accountability and Transparency

Monitor and Evaluate Policies, regularly monitoring and evaluating the effectiveness of GBV policies and support systems, making necessary adjustments based on feedback and data. Public reporting, ensure transparency by periodically reporting on the prevalence of GBV incidents and the outcomes of reported cases (while protecting the privacy of individuals involved). Hold Perpetrators accountable, ensuring that individuals found responsible for GBV are held accountable through consistent application of sanctions. The lack of accountability for offenders suggests the urgent need for stricter enforcement of policies, by implementing these comprehensive strategies, Nigerian tertiary institutions, traditional bodies social cycles can work towards creating safer, more equitable, and inclusive environments free from gender-based violence in leadership and across the entire spheres of human life.

Impact of Gender-Based Violence on Leadership

The effect of Gender-Based Violence in leadership cannot be ignored as this act deepens its impact on the social, cultural, political and economic system development and reduces the effective participation of women in leadership roles. Emphasis will be mentioned regarding the phenomenon. GBV limits effective participation of women, Smith Kamaldeen Hussein recognises that Women may internalize societal stereotypes (e.g that they are less competent leaders) affecting their performance and aspirations (8). This happens even when women reach leadership positions, it can hinder their ability to participate fully and effectively, silencing their voices and undermining their influence.

Generally, the perpetuation of gender based violence Psychological and physical harm, survivors of GBV often experience severe physical injuries, psychological trauma, anxiety, depression, and post-traumatic stress disorder. Clearly, there is no extent to the impact of gender-based violence in leadership as regards to women in the traditional leadership roles, cooperate organisation and academic institutional system, as it creates hostile environments and contributes to toxic and unsafe environments in workplaces, political arenas, and communities, making it difficult for women to thrive as leaders.

Most importantly, gender-based violence undermines democracy and development. Recognizably, when women are excluded from leadership, it weakens democratic processes and hinders inclusive and sustainable development. Research indicates that women in politics often raise overlooked issues, pass important legislation, and invest in projects that might otherwise be dismissed. Online violence affects a significant proportion of women with internet access, with nearly 60% having personally experienced some form of technology-facilitated violence

Synopsis of *The Reign of Wazobia*

The *Reign of Wazobia* is one of such plays. The play portrays the story of young women regent 'Wazobia' who rebels against the customs of her people. Wazobia projects concern over the undignified position and violence against women in her society, a situation which most

contemporary feminist scholars consider as an act of injustice meted to women in most African societies. The female protagonist “Wazobia” in the play demonstrates the basis subject matter of this study. She is equipped with certain character traits that do not only project her as unorthodox or aberrant in this patriarchal dominated society, but also, as a voice to the voiceless in such societies. Regardless of the cultural and patriarchal pressure, at the end of the play, even the traditional ridden female characters, became conscious of their beneath status in the society and unites in the quest against all forms of violence and discriminations experienced by women in leadership in the society. This study argues for the need to educate, recognize the presence, the strength, contributions and leadership of women in societal growth. This is necessary if the women must be free to participate in leadership responsibilities in nation building, beginning from the rural level, there should be equal recognition and respect accorded to women's ability for Gender-Based violence free environment.

Analysis of *The Reign of Wazobia*

Asen notes that Wazobia, the heroine cautions that the women should “spill no blood for they are the sons of our womb (186). In other words, men are not regarded as their enemies. This is a Africana womanist approach which emphasizes the need for cooperation between men and women. It is pertinent to educate and to recognize the presence, strength, contributions and the leadership of women in societal growth. This is necessary for women's free participation fair treatment and judgment in leadership positions, there should be equal respect, recognition and beginning from the rural level through; this is because, a recognition of the women's ability is a panacea for a positive development in any society, Osonye's *The Reign of Wazobia* captures how the mind of an empowered woman in leadership position operates, her wisdom in empowering, sensitizing other women towards actualization of their dream and struggle for liberation from the subjugation, stereotype and violence against women through traditions as expressed by the character Wazobia.

Wazobia: Arise, women!
They say your feet are feeble,
Show them those feet carry the burden of the womb.
They say your hands are frail, show them those hands have claws. Show them
Those hands are heavy.
Wakeup, women! Barricade the entrance to the city. I can hear trumpet
Sounds. Voices of men churning blood to drown us.
With your claws hook them but spill no blood for these are sons of our
wombs. iv

In this context, Osonye describes the effectiveness of an educated woman in a ruling position (in power). The feminist (Womanist) concept is finger pointed clearly, not only agitating for the women's right in leadership and the struggle against subjugation, oppression and

discrimination in the society, there is an important clear exposure of the need for women empowerment and negotiation for women's rightful place among men in the society. Hitherto the wisdom packed in the female power in bringing change and also a steady consideration of the place and love for men, tradition and development of the nation. This is captured in the portraiture of Wazobia's role as she requests the women to arise, making them realize their strength and self-actualization, at the same time reminding them that men are the product of their womb and as such should not be destroyed by their hands. This is the declaration of maintaining and nurturing a mindset of developing their family, culture and society even when fighting against obsolete cultural traditions.

Omu: It is our tradition that women who survive funeral rituals dance in the marketplace as Final mark of their innocence regarding their husband's death. A woman who dies morning is unclean and must be left to rot in the evil forest.

Wazobia: I see, Omu. My women will not dance naked in public to appease the eyes of a wrathful populace. This is no era for dancing to entertain lustful eyes.

Omu: But an era of what? This is no matter for big grammar or high bloated “isms” and Ideologies!

Wazobia: But of What? (18).

Omu: Tradition! Tradition as we met it. Tradition passed down to us from the time when the world's eye were still closed. Tradition handed down from generation to generation. Tradition! Tradition Wa-zo-bia (19).

Wazobia: The face of the sun changes, so does the moon. Season too changes, so does the face of the clock. The clock ticks. (19)

Wazobia, who is a regent, a supposed custodian of Ilah tradition, bluntly refuses to allow the Omuto carry out the ritual of widows dancing naked at the market square for the men to watch and satisfy their eyes. She perceives that act as degrading and disrespectful to women who are helpless in the hands of the so called generational tradition of the kingdom. Since the women have no voice to speak against the awful ritual practices, Wazobia deems it fit to object to it and liberate them women giving the power and voice they deserve.

Wazobia's doggedness and perceived arrogance is stated in her utterance, which can only be effectively interpreted as her strong will to remain in power as the leader to enable her eradicate culturally designed practices against women, which serve as hindrance to women participation

in decision making and leadership in the kingdom

Wazobia: Ha! Ha! Ha! For three seasons, Wazobia has reigned, Three seasons, just three seasons, and men are sweating in their anuses. Three seasons!! That is their maximum for any female regent interregnum, like Military intervention but I have known Military intervention last 10,15, 20 years! I have only intervened here three seasons, wiping their nose, cleaning their tears and now they want me to step down.(1)

This study explores Tess Osonye Onwueme's *The Reign of Wazobia*, in the analysis of the play text, she captures gender based violence against women in leadership position in a typical Nigerian society, just like the works of other female playwrights and how they discuss issues affecting African women in the society, exposing harmful cultural practices against women with emphasis on gender based violence as such as other issues like gender inequality, discrimination, subjugation etc. She insists that most African cultures are obsolete and degrading to women. She discusses issues of Gender-based violence and women inclusiveness in leadership roles in the society by exposing entrenched patriarchal traditions, re-enforced by men putting women in a passive and demining state. Women are confined to limited participation, deliberate pressure on women to undergo demining traditions and domestic violence in marriages. *The Reign of Wazobia* challenges such issues, by bringing to us a scenario of an empowered woman (Wazobia) who is an educated young Regent, who rules and competes with men, defeats them in their patriarchic behavior towards women, challenging exploitative traditions and securing a befitting space for women, defining their rights and encouraging them to be empowered, giving them voices and autonomy, enabling them to see their strength for participation in leadership space, in politic, in economy and family responsibilities and decision making towards the development of the nation. Women leadership, empowerment and equal participation is key factors that determines the successful uplifting in the status and position of women in the society and grant them a pivotal role in national development. Thus for any society or nation to progress positively, there is need for the eradication of Gender based violence to embrace progressive and steady changes.

Discussion of Findings

The findings of this study, notes that the normalization of violence against women in leadership across all public spheres of human structural operations, is reinforced by patriarchal values, where women are considered inferior or deserving mistreatment and underrepresented. This discrimination and mistreatment is as a result of typical African perception where women and girls are treated unequally and denied equal rights, respect and opportunity. Considering the experiences of women and girls in the public spheres, it can be agreed that women in leadership experience one form of gender-based violence in their life time drawing from the play text, women tend to experience GBV from the cultural institution through more socialized environment. Addressing gender-based violence is crucial for achieving gender equality in leadership and creating environments where all individuals can contribute their talents and

leadership potential without fear of violence and discrimination. This requires a collective effort from individuals, communities, civil society organizations, and government agencies to implement legal frameworks, challenge harmful social norms, and provide support for survivors.

Finally, the findings observe that lack of communication and awareness in typical and more sophisticated system has been a factor responsible for increase in gender-based violence in leadership, equally lack of counseling structures for younger women, female students in schools and inadequate operational gender studies centres for enlightenment and workshop amongst women in traditional settings and institutions have hindered women knowledge on their rights and the purpose of empowerment and participation in leadership role and responsibilities.

Conclusion

Addressing gender-based violence in leadership in Nigerian requires a multifaceted approach involving policy reform, cultural change, and the empowerment of individuals at all levels of the traditional or social institutions as it creates a baseline for effective policies and measures to be implemented by these bodies of institutions which will enable a better evidence based and stringent understanding of the weightiness of the issue with its various features, expression and forms. Collaborative efforts between the government, custodians of tradition, educational institutions, and civil society are crucial to foster a safe and equitable leadership environment. Most importantly, without addressing gender-based violence in leadership in Nigerian, we cannot work towards ending it in physical social circles, society, on media platforms and academic environments in Nigeria.

Recommendations

Recognizing and addressing gender-based violence in leadership in Nigerian, it is crucial for creating more equitable, inclusive, and effective leadership and habitable environment for women and girls at all levels.

- i. There should be documented legal frameworks for implementing and enforcing laws that prohibit all forms of gender-based violence and provision for institutional Policies, the need for developing and implementing workplace and organizational policies that prevent and address gender-based violence GBV, including clear reporting mechanisms and support for victims.
- ii. There should be more cloud platforms rooted with indigenous gender leadership education to promoting and raising awareness about gender-based violence GBV and its impact, challenging harmful gender norms, and promoting gender equality and rights of girls and women in the society.
- iii. Nigerian education institutions should encourage for support systems by providing support services for individuals who experience GBV, including counseling, legal aid, and protection.
- iv. Government and cultural institutions should create measures for accountability, by ensuring that perpetrators of gender based violence GBV are held accountable for their

actions.

- v. The Government should support in promoting inclusive leadership which will help in fostering environments where diverse leaders, regardless of gender, can thrive and contribute equally.

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